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The Evolution of Family Policy: Lessons Learned, Challenges, and Hopes for the Future

Over the past 50 years, the new field of family policy has built a substantial knowledge base, developed a robust theoretical and analytic framework, and created strong individual and organizational leadership. The field addresses an ever-widening series of complex and often highly controversial areas of family life and has achieved considerable success. Yet the results of family policy remain largely unknown to and undervalued by academics, policymakers, the media, and the general public. This article outlines underlying value tensions and barriers but also points out that significant progress has been made in finding common ground in areas such as work–family policies, teen pregnancy prevention, child welfare services, domestic violence, couples and marriage education, and fatherhood programs. Yet much more remains to be done in several areas such as long-term care and family caregiving. Establishing Family Matters Commissions in states could help family policy become a more visible, compelling, effective, and regular part of policymaking.

Fifty years ago the well-being of families emerged as a public issue in the United States. This shift transpired after several prominent scholars and public officials strongly argued that family life should become a legitimate subject for public study, debate, and national action. Dramatic changes in family structure and gender roles raised concerns about effects on children and society at large. In her widely read book *The Nation and the Family*, Alva Myrdal (1941), a Swedish social scientist, worried about the decline in the birth rate and urged government to provide more supports to working parents. In 1965, Daniel P. Moynihan, aide to President Nixon, wrote what later became known as the Moynihan Report (1965). In it, he identified family instability, especially the high rates of single parenthood among African American communities as a principal cause of poverty and, hence, a prime concern for government.

In 1973 Senator Walter Mondale (D-MN) took up the theme, and as chair of the Senate Subcommittee on Children, Youth and Families he presided over a series of hearings known as *American Families: Trends and Pressures* (U.S. Congress, 1974). In 1976, Jimmy Carter then pledged to strengthen the American family in his presidential campaign speeches as well as in his inaugural address in 1977. In 1980, the three-part White House Conference on Families was held, and the field of family policy was officially launched.

President Carter's defeat in the November 1980 elections prevented follow-up on many constructive ideas and recommendations made at the conference (Shane, 1981). Nevertheless, over the following four decades, the field expanded considerably in scope. Numerous conferences, commissions, and a large and growing body of research have worked to improve the understanding of family problems and to identify ways to strengthen and support families, thereby improving child well-being (see Bane, 1996; Cherlin, 2010; Keniston & Carnegie Council on Children, 1977; Garfinkel

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& McLanahan, 1986; Schorr, 1989; Waite & Gallagher, 2000; Whitehead, 1997; Wilson, 1987). In the process, new organizations, government units, and philanthropic foundations actively engaged with scholars and family professionals.

The ongoing evolution of family policy I review here remains a very complex, messy, uncoordinated, enthralling, and at times highly controversial undertaking. But in my view, the substantial progress family policy has made to date and its contribution to improving children's and families' lives have largely been unrecognized and are greatly undervalued by academic disciplines, policymakers, the media, and the general public.

Widespread agreement now exists on the centrality of family life to individuals and society at large, and many new programs and policies are in place to help support and strengthen families. Although there have been some setbacks, much has been accomplished throughout both recent Democratic and Republican administrations toward building the infrastructure needed for a new arena of policy to grow and flourish. However, in the 2010s, the progress slowed, and by 2018, it seemed to have stalled. In 2008, Karen Bogenschneider and Thomas Corbett—two of the leading scholar-practitioners in the field—stated, "Arguably, family policy is still not a term that is widely used by knowledge consumers, such as policymakers, journalists, or the public" (Bogenschneider & Corbett, 2010, p. 783). A decade later, in 2018, this statement remains true. In short, family policy seems to be an unwanted stepchild of social policy.

I begin this review by identifying several crosscutting themes and tensions threaded throughout the story. Second, I present an overview of some of the main building blocks involved in developing the leadership needed for the field of family policy. Third, I summarize the somewhat "bumpy" expansion of the field to include an ever-wider range of problems and solutions. Fourth, I discuss five family policy topics that were initially considered highly controversial but are now much more broadly accepted. Fifth, I suggest several specific family policy issues that most need to be addressed in the future, along with some of the academic and system barriers that may impede further progress. Finally, I propose a state-based reform strategy to help move the field forward and get public officials, the media, and the public at large to take family policy issues seriously.

I do not claim that this account is a comprehensive or even a dispassionate review; instead, it represents my personal snapshot of the story. For most of this period, I was a ringside observer and part-time participant. I came to Washington, DC, in the mid-1970s from a background as a psychiatric social worker and family therapist providing clinical services to low-income families and their children in New Haven, Connecticut, and Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. In the nation's capital city, I became fascinated by the complex processes, multiple institutions and actors, and bewildering array of acronyms involved in government policy. I found public officials in U.S. Congress and executive branch agencies working hard to improve the lives of children and families, but they clearly needed to know more about the realities of families' lives to develop sound and effective policy. For the following three decades, while working in Washington, I became one of a growing group of "knowledge brokers" (policy analysts) striving to create information bridges between policymakers, child and family researchers, and practitioners. I served as director of the Family Impact Seminar—a small nonprofit think tank embedded in several larger organizations from 1988 through 2006—and then worked as a consultant on couples and marriage policy in a handful of states and communities, most intensively in Oklahoma.

Crosscutting Themes and Tensions in the Story of Family Policy

I begin by highlighting four overarching themes that are threaded throughout this story and that may help explain why family policy is treated as an unwanted stepchild of social policy—competing and confusing values; confusion about the definition, scope, and domain of family policy; tensions among different family stakeholders; and ideological tension between individualism and familism.

Competing and Confusing Values

In poll after poll around the world, families and family life are very highly valued. In the United States, politicians are quick to use pro-family rhetoric in their speeches to obtain public support (Strach, 2007). Bogenschneider

(2014) asked, "If policymakers, professionals and the public so strongly endorse the importance of families to a strong and vital society, why does family policy still take a back seat?" (p. 29). Bogenschneider suggests that recent rapid changes in family structure and gender roles create uncertainty and confusion about whether and how to respond, and what the appropriate role of government should be. She also cites the lack of institutions and professionals trained to understand how to communicate with policymakers and translate the growing body of family research into evidence-based policies and programs.

In my view, an additional reason is the tendency to sugarcoat family issues—to describe families always in saccharine terms and fail to openly acknowledge the ambivalent feelings and dark sides of family life. Family relationships are indeed the source of our deepest joys, hopes, pleasures, support, and satisfaction, but they can also be a source of great disappointment, pain, anger, failure, frustration, even violence, as well as burdensome obligation. It may be easier to avoid discussions about family policy because they may open up many mixed and ambivalent feelings that are uncomfortable to deal with. There can be no denying, however, that family is a powerful and critically important aspect of almost all our lives, which we cannot ignore or trivialize.

Strong families always have been highly valued by American civil and religious society but historically were viewed as a private sphere—"a haven in a heartless world" and the basic caring institution for individuals—but beyond the reach of government (Steiner, 1981, pp. 4–5). Family policy issues are often highly polarized, tossed around like a political football. Conservative Republicans take turns with liberal Democrats to become "champions" of supporting families in one moment and then turn around and decry government intrusion in family life in the next.

Confusion About the Definition, Scope, and Domain of Family Policy

In the early years, acrimonious debates about the definitions and specific terms used in family policy created initial stumbling blocks to reasonable discourse. For example, to allay fears that the planned Carter administration White House Conference on the Family was designed to impose one single model of family life—the White, married, two-parent family with a male breadwinner—the conference organizers decided early on to acknowledge family diversity of structure, race/ethnicity, income level, and religion by changing the conference name to the plural—White House Conference on Families. This name change did help rally more positive interest and support, but the suspicions remained and periodically resurface.

Similarly, critics pilloried the key recommendation of the Carnegie Council on Children and others to define "a [i.e., singular] comprehensive national family policy" (Steiner, 1981, p. 23). This was generally acknowledged to be as fruitless a task as trying to define for the nation a singular comprehensive economic or environmental policy.

In these early discussions, debates about how to define *family* eventually proved pointless and unnecessary. No single definition is possible, because it will vary depending on the context and purpose. To clarify the scope and domain of family policy, I focus on two dimensions— direct and indirect. Some policies I discuss here are considered family policies because they directly address the varied responsibilities and functions that family members perform for individuals and society. This article also discusses policies that, while directly addressing individual needs and well-being, also affect and involve family relationships indirectly. These benefit by using a family lens to determine whether and how family members are related to the individual's problem or need, and whether the proposed intervention or service would be more effective and efficient by taking the family influence into account.

Tensions Among Different Family Stakeholders

Another recurring tension is that many people seem to assume that the term *family* refers only, or primarily, to mothers with children. The story of the evolution of family policy demonstrates a gradual awakening to the fact that individuals, fathers, and couples (whether never-married, separated, cohabiting, married or divorced, and parents or not), as well as grandparents, siblings, aunts, and uncles, are all members of families and can have important roles to play, which policymakers and service providers may need to pay attention to. Children, mothers and women, and fathers and men all have skin in the family game, but their interests sometimes conflict.

The children's advocacy movement—which has deep, historical roots in a "child-saving era" in the late 19th century (Takanishi, 1978)—has continued to progress in parallel, separate fashion and sometimes seems to be in opposition to the emerging interest in family policy. Historically, organizations that champion the rights of children and youth have been somewhat wary of including parents and families in their mission statements and focus of activities. These children's advocacy organizations are sometimes criticized for supporting interventions to "rescue" children from poor, incompetent parents. Women's rights groups are especially nervous of family-focused programs that could end up denying them the ability to work outside the home or force them to remain with an abusive or neglectful husband or father of children. Some family-focused advocates appear to be unaware of the need to protect children from neglectful or abusive parents, or spouses from each other's violent behavior.

We are now much more attuned to recognizing the tension between women's and men's interests not only outside the family but also within the family. Jessie Bernard's (1982) influential book, *The Future of Marriage*, emphasized that there were two marriages in every marriage—his and hers. She concluded that family was an inherently unequal institution that, in general, benefited men more than women. Feminists' efforts to gain equal rights for women in the workplace and society have resulted in major changes in gender roles within the home. Especially in two-earner families, the tasks of housework and parenting are becoming more equally shared, and workplace policies regarding family leave and child care have improved.

In the past several decades, these tensions have been reduced and sometimes even resolved when child, feminist, fatherhood, and family-focused champions and organizations learned to work together, respect one another's perspective and emphasis, and find areas of common ground. Many child advocates now acknowledge the mounting evidence that involving and working not only with the mother but with both parents in the school or in health and other programs generally leads to better outcomes for children and teens (see Bogenschneider, 2014; Cowan & Cowan, 2019). Feminists and gay rights advocates initially skeptical of government efforts to strengthen marriage now acknowledge that studies affirm a large majority of people want to marry and to have their marriage last. And, as I note later, those who focus on efforts to preserve couples and family units have worked out protocols about how to do so safely.

Ideological Tensions Between Individualism and Familism

A major challenge that the family policy field must confront is that American society is deeply rooted in individualism. The U.S. Constitution makes no mention of family, and federal and state laws, programs, and services are generally designed to focus on the needs and rights of individuals. Thus, viewing individuals in their family, relational context is not a trivial matter—it implies a profound shift in perspective from only "seeing" and thinking about the individual (individualism) to seeing and thinking about them in the context of family and other close relationships (what some call familism and others, communitarianism).

Familism is not a familiar term beyond academia. Yet if individualism signifies the primacy of pursuing individual interests, rights, and needs, then familism, in contrast, is an ideology that subordinates individual personal interests to those of family (or those who function "as family"). Family policy advocates, however, do not assume that individuals' interests are always subservient; they assert that those interests need to be acknowledged and weighed and balanced with the rights and interests of other family members and with the family's well-being as a whole. Furstenberg (1981), in reporting on his research on teen parenthood, notes, "In part, the neglect of the family is, then, an unconscious abdication more than a deliberate oversight. Unless we are prepared to correct this individualistic bias in our programs, we must be willing to concede that our efforts at intervention will be slight" (p. 163). The key question, then, is how can this shift to acknowledge the importance of the family context best be achieved? I return to this question later.

Development of Leadership for the Field of Family Policy

The Family Impact Seminar (FIS), a small nonprofit organization, was set up with foundation support in 1976 to explore the substantive and political feasibility of developing family

impact statements. This suggestion made by witnesses at the 1973 Senate hearings was referring to the 1989 U.S. law (National Environmental Policy Act) requiring the preparation of environmental impact statements (EIS). The EIS strategy has been quite successful in alerting the public to concerns about the physical environment, and thus it was hoped that an FIS strategy would achieve similar benefits for the human and family environment (Ooms, 1995).

The FIS was launched and initially directed by A. Sidney Johnson, the former staff director of the Senate subcommittee on Children, Youth and Families. The organization benefited greatly from the advice and intense interest and work of a 24-member advisory group of prominent scholars, professionals, and policymakers who met several times a year in its early years and intermittently later on. Developing the infrastructure needed for the field of family policy to grow in influence included identifying a conceptual framework to guide theory, research, and practice; creating a knowledge base and analytic capacity; advancing evaluation of family policies and programs; and supporting "star" individuals and organizations to monitor and guide the field.

Identifying a Conceptual Framework to Guide Theory, Research, and Practice

The first task of the Family Impact Seminar was somewhat abstract—namely, to lay out the theory that should underpin policymakers' practical adoption of a family lens. Family and ecological systems theory quickly emerged as the best theoretical foundation for family policy. Ecological family systems theory integrates child psychologist Urie Bronfenbrenner's concentric, nested circles model of human ecology and was already widely accepted by child development scholars and practitioners (Bronfenbrenner, 1979). This was merged with child and family therapist Salvador Minuchin's structural family systems theory and lays out the range of relationship dynamics between individual family members and their interactions with their economic and social environment (Minuchin, 1974). This integrated theoretical approach is a radical shift away from the individualistic, linear theories that guided (and still guide) most of the major academic and practice disciplines in the United States, as well as the actions of public officials. Introducing this ecological perspective to any topic adds greater depth and complexity. To adapt a metaphor from Salvador Minuchin, it is like shifting from a still camera with black-and-white film and a fixed-focus lens to a movie camera in color with a zoom lens.

Ecological family systems theory is not widely known or used outside of child development and mental health circles, but it gradually became infused into the highly practical conceptual framework that guided many of the early family impact studies and activities, and, as discussed later, it is gradually creeping into use in education, health, and human services, especially at the service-delivery level.

The framework was initially hammered out through the collective work of the FIS staff and advisers and tested in three major studies on foster care, teen pregnancy, and work–life balance (Bohen & Viveros-Long, 1981, Hubbell, 1981; Ooms, 1981). The framework was revised with additional input from the Coalition of Family Organizations, an ad hoc group of five national organizations of scholars and family professionals (American Association of Marriage and Family Therapy, American Home Economics Association, Family Service America, Family Impact Seminar, and the National Council on Family Relations) working together in the 1980s to educate and promote family policy and family-centered services. The family impact framework was then revised and elaborated on by the Family Impact Seminar successor organization, the Policy Institute for Family Impact Seminars, based from 1999 to 2014 at the University of Wisconsin–Madison, and today by the Family Impact Institute based at Purdue University.

To make it of practical use, the framework includes key principles and checklists of questions and other tools designed to guide the analysis of family impact in a wide variety of situations and time frames. These are presented and summarized in a major textbook (Bogenschneider, 2014), in an empirical article (Bogenschneider et al., 2012), and in several shorter, accessible publications designed for use at hearings and in other settings.[1] This framework guided the work of the Family Impact Seminar over the following four decades in

[1]Checklists, rationale, handbook, and policymaker's guide are available at the Family Impact Institute's website, at https://www.purdue.edu/hhs/hdfs/fii/family-impact/.

conducting 44 seminars on Capitol Hill, several in-depth studies, conferences, and roundtable meetings. It continues to guide the work of the Family Impact Institute network, which has conducted 225 Family Impact Seminars in state capitols.

The framework outlines how and why any analysis of family impact needs to consider the following five major dimensions of family roles and functioning: (a) family formation and membership; (b) family and couple partner relationships; (c) responsibility to provide economic support; (d) caring, educating, and raising children; and (e) providing protective care to the frail elderly, children, and family members who are chronically ill and disabled. To carry out these various tasks and responsibilities, parents and other family members work, coordinate, and manage complex relationships with their bosses and colleagues and a host of other professionals, community members, and service providers. When families perform these tasks well, we are assured that society has healthy, productive workers and caring, committed citizens. When families cannot perform these tasks or do not do so well enough, government welfare assistance, health, education, and social service programs are needed to take over for, support, or supplement families—at huge financial cost to taxpayers. This is the main reason family issues are of public, not just private, concern. Moreover, from research and practice, we have learned that approaches that focus on families have been found to be more cost efficient than those that focus solely on the individual (Bogenschneider, 2000; Bogenschneider & Corbett, 2010).

At the Family Impact Seminar we gradually came to believe that our initial focus on assessing family impact was probably too limited and too linear a concept. Asking what harm or benefits government actions and policies do to families means that family members are typically seen as passive recipients. A more accurate view is to consider the relationship of government (or programs) to family life as one of partnership, and then the overarching question becomes, how well does the policy or program help families fulfill their roles and responsibilities—does it help or hinder them (Cherlin, 1984; Moroney, 1980)?

Creating a Knowledge Base and Analytic Capacity

After first mapping the theory, the second major accomplishment was to improve the availability of more and better quality national statistics and research to inform and guide child, youth, and family policies. The inadequacy of existing data and research was a key topic at the Family Impact Seminar members' initial meeting with Vice President Mondale in the White House in June 1977 and in their work thereafter.

Over the following three decades, as a result of the urging of scholars, the Family Impact Seminar and other organizations, government statistical agencies, and academic associations collaborated to expand and improve the federal decennial census, and a few national surveys of children and families were expanded or launched (Moore, 2019). Two school-based surveys began to collect longitudinal data about adolescents—the ongoing Monitoring the Future at the University of Michigan (1975) and the CDC-funded Youth Risk Behavior Surveillance Survey (1990). Then the Fragile Families and Child Wellbeing Study was launched (with multiple sources of funding) at the Woodrow Wilson School of Public and International Affairs, Princeton University. Sara McClanahan, Kathryn Edin, and Ronald Mincy were the co–principal investigators. The Fragile Families survey is following for 15 years nearly 5,000 children and their families born in large U.S. cities from 1998 to 2000. (The survey coined the term *fragile families* to refer to the 3,000 nonmarital children in the sample—82% of whose parents were found to be cohabiting or dating.) These fragile families are a population at high risk of poverty and family breakup. This study continues to generate quantities of information and is helping to shape family policy, particularly in low-income communities (Kowaleski-Jones & Wolfinger, 2006; Parke, 2004)

Another important milestone in knowledge and capacity building for family policy was the Federal Interagency Forum on Child and Family Statistics, founded in 1994 by an executive order. The forum is a collection of 23 federal government agencies involved in research and activities related to children and families. Its mission is to foster coordination and collaboration between researchers to enhance and

improve consistency in the collection, reporting, and dissemination of federal data on children and families. The forum's annual report *America's Children: Key National Indicators of Well-Being* is an invaluable summary of national indicators of child well-being. In addition to providing data in an easy-to-use, nontechnical format, the report stimulates discussions among policymakers and the public, exchanges between data providers and policy communities, and improvements in federal data on children and families.

Progress toward collecting more and better indicator data has, however, suffered some setbacks. In 1995, the National Center for Health Statistics, facing continuing cost pressures and anticipated budget cuts, discontinued the collection of all national marriage and divorce statistics, which led many in the research community to strongly protest. Three years later, the Census Bureau decided to discontinue the marital status question asked on the short form of the decennial census (the version that more than 80% of Americans receive). More recently, at the July 2018 Forum on Evidence-Based Policy organized by the Brookings Institution, a panelist mentioned several steps the Trump administration had already taken to curb, end, or make more difficult data collection and research in human services (Haskins, 2018).

Several nonpartisan, nonprofit organizations play a national leadership role in continuously providing data, research, and analysis about children and families, and improving its quantity and quality. Most notably, Child Trends (founded in 1979) conducts and publishes research and analysis on children, youth, and family well-being and the effectiveness of programs. The Pew Research Center conducts public opinion polls, surveys, and research analysis on a wide scope of national policy issues and has always had a special interest in monitoring family demographic trends. In addition, the Annie E. Casey Foundation publishes for each state an annual Kids Count data book, *State Trends in Child Wellbeing*. The National Center for Family and Marriage Research at Bowling Green University in Ohio conducts and disseminates research on how family structure affects health and well-being. The National Marriage Project, originally based at Rutgers and founded by David Popenoe and Barbara Dafoe Whitehead, published annually for several years the invaluable *State of Our Union* report. Bradford Wilcox, who directs the Institute for Family Studies at the University of Virginia, is planning to restart a similar annual publication.

Advancing Evaluation of Family Policies and Programs

The availability of more and better national and state survey data, supplemented by small qualitative studies, has helped us learn much more about the characteristics and patterns of family life across the nation and to better monitor indicators of their well-being (Moore, 2019). Faced with decisions about whether to expand funding for services to address family needs, government officials began increasingly to ask for data, not only on the size and extent of the problems but also on what strategies and services actually work to solve the problem or better meet the need. Happily, in recent decades, the subfield of program evaluation has grown and become more prominent and led to the growing interest in evidence-based policy. More rigorous methods of program evaluation such as randomized controlled trials (RCTs)—adopted from the medical field—were further developed and tested mostly in the welfare and employment areas. There was also growing interest in using administrative data and documenting the details of program implementation (Lennon & Corbett, 2003; Rossi, Lipsey, & Freeman, 2004).

All these improvements in data and evaluation added forward momentum to the evolution of family policy. Positive outcomes emerged from several rigorous evaluations of family-focused, early childhood programs—such as Head Start, the Olds Nurse Home Visiting Partnership—and a few high-quality preschool programs, including the Perry Preschool Project, the Chicago Child–Parent Center, and the Abecedarian Project (Bogenschneider & Corbett, 2010).

The White House Office of Management and Budget launched nationwide the movement for evidence-driven policy in the early 2000s to help prioritize programs for funding in health and human services. Initially, the office worked in collaboration with the nonprofit Coalition for Evidence-Based Policy and others to promote the concept, and in doing so, it drew on many examples in the child and family arena, such as the evidence of success of certain models of programs for teen pregnancy prevention (Baron, 2018). In 2016, U.S.

Congress passed the Evidence-Based Policy Act of 2016, creating the bipartisan Commission on Evidence-Based Policymaking. After a year of wide-ranging study and fact-finding, the commission's report was released in September 2017 (Commission on Evidence-Based Policymaking, 2017). Further, the July 2018 *Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* published a comprehensive set of articles assessing the promise and challenges of the evidence-based movement (Haskins, 2018; Knox, Hill, & Berlin, 2018). "Despite important recent advances . . . evidence-based approaches have so far only gained a foothold in social policy; the majority of social spending is still allocated with little regard to rigorous evidence of what works" (Baron, 2018, p. 48).

Supporting "Star" Individuals and Organizations to Monitor, Promote, and Guide the Field

The third major achievement has been the intense interest and involvement of several "stars"—namely leading researchers and family professionals working in government, universities, nonprofit service and advocacy organizations, and the private sector at national, state, and local levels—who have become champions of particular areas of family policy. Over the years, they have had a strong influence on the development of the field.

Among the most prominent of these national child and family champions over the past 40 years are civil rights lawyer, Marian Wright Edelman, who founded and leads the Children's Defense Fund; economist Isabel A. Sawhill, who cofounded and is president of the National Campaign to Prevent Teen Pregnancy, and also codirects with Ron Haskins the Center on Families and Children at the Brookings Institution; Ronald Mincy, Columbia University professor and codirector of the Fragile Families study; and Wade Horn, founder and president of the National Fatherhood Institute and assistant secretary for children and families during the Bush administration.

These champions and many other scholars, public officials, and organizational leaders often spoke publicly and testified at congressional hearings about the urgent challenges of child and family poverty, family breakup, and fragility. They served as key knowledge brokers, working to bridge the fields of research, practice, and policy, and through their efforts and those of many others, they achieved substantial results.

Many organizations have also played a critical role. The Society for Research in Child Development is one of several organizations that sponsor yearlong fellowships on Capitol Hill to help bridge the gap between research and policy. Bogenschneider (2014) listed around 50 research and advocacy organizations focusing on family issues that include liberal- and conservative-leaning groups. Among the most prominent of the think tanks is the Brookings Institution, which set up the Center for Children and Families in 2005. This center, among many other activities, collaborates with the Wilson Center at Princeton University to organize two conferences each year on family issues and publishes the papers in a journal, *The Future of Children*. The nonpartisan Urban Institute, the progressive Council for Contemporary Families, and conservative-leaning think tanks like the Family Research Council, Heritage Foundation, American Enterprise Institute and, recently, the Witherspoon Institute, have shown considerable interest in research on family issues. The large research firms Mathematica Policy Research, MDRC, and ABT Associates have also conducted a great deal of policy research and program evaluation on a wide range of family policy issues. At the state level, Penn State University has held annual conferences on a variety of family issues, and more than 225 Family Impact Seminars have been held in state capitols as part of a network associated with the Family Impact Institute at Purdue University.

Expansion of the Field of Family Policy

Many academics and public commentators believe that family issues are a relatively new focus for government and are few in number. When asked to give examples of family policy, most cite child care, family leave, and abortion, and then have difficulty thinking of others. Yet the extent to which a wide range of family issues are already embedded in existing law and the fact that a large number of family-focused programs are already funded by federal and state governments are not well understood or appreciated. Family membership also helps determine the eligibility for many services and financial benefits provided to individuals.

Expansion of the Scope of Family Policies

In 1977, the Family Impact Seminar reviewed the Federal Catalog of Domestic Assistance Programs and identified more than 1,000 federal programs that provided some kind of assistance to families. Two decades later, in 1997, the U.S. General Accounting Office (today the Government Accountability Office) published an overview of all the federal laws in which benefits, rights, and privileges are contingent on marital status. The 1,049 laws identified fell into 13 categories, including Social Security, veterans' benefits, taxation, and immigration. To demonstrate the recent expansion of the field, Bogenschneider (2014) listed and briefly described numerous family policies enacted into law by U.S. Congress between 1990 and 2012. Granted, this listing would have been much longer were state family policies included.

Ever since President Johnson launched the War on Poverty in 1964, a focus on family income—especially how best to reduce child and family poverty—has been a prominent theme in social welfare discussions. Senator Moynihan's concern about poverty among female-headed families with children led to President Nixon's ill-fated proposal for a guaranteed income—the Family Assistance Plan. This was followed by decades of debates about how best to reform the child-support-enforcement program and welfare programs, especially the Aid to Families With Dependent Children (AFDC) cash benefit program for single mothers. Debates centered on whether providing cash or in-kind assistance (e.g., food stamps) to low-income individuals encourages long-term dependency on government and thus discourages work. On the basis of the experience of several innovative state welfare-reform demonstrations, AFDC was transformed in 1996 into the Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) block grants to states to provide cash assistance to single-headed households and some two-parent families. These grants were contingent on recipients beginning to work within 2 years, and there was a lifetime limit to benefits of 5 years. (State funds often supplemented the federal grants with child-care assistance.)

The federal tax code and Social Security are large policy domains that include many provisions based on family status; for example, there are now three big federal tax credits for low-income parents (i.e., child tax, child and dependent care, and earned income). The earned income tax credit initially passed in 1975 and then expanded in the 1990s; together with the child and dependent care tax credit, it has broad bipartisan support. These two programs have reduced the poverty of millions of families with children, and they also promote work and benefit child development (Marr, Huang, Sherman, & Debot, 2015). There are also various marriage bonuses and penalties embedded in the federal tax code (U.S. Congress, 1997). For several decades, the federal government has led efforts to strengthen the child support system, with considerable success in increasing collection rates and establishing paternity and child support orders, as well as providing a range of family-oriented services.

Other noteworthy developments to expand the field included a long-overdue recognition of the role, rights, and responsibilities of married and unwed fathers in family policy discussions (Lerman & Ooms, 1993). A growing body of research on fathers and fatherhood (Blankenhorn, 1996; Lamb, 2010; Mincy, Jethwani, & Klempin, 2015) contributed to the founding of several organizations that led to the emergence of the multipronged responsible fatherhood "movement," focusing especially on subpopulations of fathers who were disconnected from their children for different reasons (see Ooms, Cohen, & Hutchins, 1995). The Children's Rights Council represented mostly middle-class, divorced fathers insisting on rights to custody and visitation. Numerous community-based responsible fatherhood programs helped low-income, noncustodial, and mostly urban African American fathers deal with the child support system, find jobs, reconnect with their children, and learn better parenting skills. The National Fatherhood Initiative offered information and advocacy for fathers around the country. Initially, responsible fatherhood programs received funding primarily from foundations, but today several are funded with federal discretionary grants through the TANF program

Expansion of Family-Centered Services

The progress of an emerging policy field should not be measured solely by assessing the number of new federal or state laws and programs, how many families received a new service, or the amount of money spent on them. What can be just as important is what actually happens

at the service-delivery level and what the outcomes are. Do family members feel understood, respected, involved, and even empowered? Are the services different family members received being effectively coordinated with one another? There is some good news here with a slow but steady trend toward implementing so-called family-friendly services. I illustrate this trend here using the issues of health care and education.

First, health care. Numerous studies provide robust evidence of the critical role that families play in promoting healthy lifestyles and preventing disease, and in the effectiveness of treatment, especially for the chronically ill (see Bogenschneider, 2014). This awareness happily has led to family-centered models of health-care delivery, and some of these are being supported by a few significant changes in policy. Many more low-income children received access to health care through the passage of the State Children's Health Insurance Program (SCHIP) in 1997, later expanded in 2009. In addition, the passage of the Affordable Care Act (i.e., Obamacare) in 2010 greatly increased the availability of health care to low-income families. But the focus in some of these welcome reforms remains on services given to individual children in the family, not the family as a whole. For example, SCHIP funds in most states cannot be spent on providing health care to the child's parent living in the same house.

The Institute for Healthcare Improvement, an influential nonprofit research and advocacy organization founded in 1991 to promote innovation and more cost-effective health-care services, includes person- and family-centered health care as one of five core components of its mission. Around the same time, the Institute for Patient and Family-Centered Care began to identify the numerous ways in which health-care professionals, and the hospitals and other buildings they worked in, were not "friendly" to patients and families and, in fact, discouraged the information sharing, collaboration, and mutual respect among health-care professionals, patients, and family considered so essential to effective health care (Johnson & Abraham, 2012).

Second, children's education. Education, as often noted, is a responsibility shared by parents and schools. But too often families and schools are considered "worlds apart" (Lightfoot, 1978). Parents' role is typically limited to choosing the school (where there is a choice), attending parent–teacher association meetings, and ensuring that their children attend school and do homework. A landmark law passed in 1976, the Education for All Handicapped Children Act, pioneered a new model of shared responsibility in education. This law, later folded into the Individuals With Disabilities Act of 1990, required schools to assess each ill or disabled child's educational needs and to develop an appropriate educational plan. Parents are required to be involved in developing the plan and to sign it, and then they can dispute the decisions made if they wish. Gradually, some of these new parent involvement practices used initially in programs for children with disabilities began to be instituted for the benefit of all children in a school.

The National Committee for Citizens in Education led this movement with the publication of a book in 1986, *Beyond the Bake Sale: An Educator's Guide to Working With Parents*, which was widely distributed to parents and teachers across the country (Henderson, Marburger, & Ooms, 1986). This was more recently updated by a comprehensive review of studies that demonstrated that children do best when parents are involved in schooling and described the variety of ways that parents from many different backgrounds can and should be involved (Henderson & Mapp, 2002). Many communities now have organizations or consultants that promote "family-friendly" schools where teachers, counselors, and therapists work in partnership together with parents (Eno, 2019).

Addressing Controversial Family Issues

I now turn to five family policy topics that, when first discussed, caused enormous controversy but have since developed much broader support and acceptance, partly through the passage of time, as there have been many changes in family and parenting behavior (births, marriage, divorce, living arrangements, employment patterns) and in social values and attitudes. The five topics discussed here are balancing work and family life, teen pregnancy prevention, child welfare, domestic violence, and couples and marriage.

Work and Family Life

A great deal of progress has been reached in balancing work and family since it was first placed

on the public agenda (Bohen & Viveros-Long, 1981). It is now firmly agreed that child care is an essential support for nearly all families with children. This was not the case in 1971, when Congress passed the Child Care Development Bill, which proposed a national system of comprehensive child development and day-care centers. President Nixon vetoed the bill on the grounds that it would "commit the vast moral authority of the National Government to the side of communal approaches to child-rearing over against the family-centered approach" (Steiner, 1981, p. 91). Clearly, at that time many people still believed that mothers should stay at home and in the kitchen. Nixon's veto set child-care policy back many years.

The contrast with today's views is striking. It is now widely accepted that mothers are employed and, hence, child-care subsidies have increased, flexible work schedules are more often available, and public and private employers routinely provide unpaid family leave to mothers, and sometimes also to fathers, at the birth of their child—due largely to the passage of the Family and Medical Leave Act in 1993. But there is still much more work to do to improve the accessibility and quality of child care, and the United States remains the only major industrialized country that does not provide paid family leave.

Teen Pregnancy Prevention

Teen pregnancy prevention shifted from being a very sensitive, controversial topic in the early 1980s to one of family policy's major success stories. In the mid-1970s, the public became alarmed at the escalating rates of teen pregnancy and births. Researchers detailed the negative economic, social, and psychological consequences of early childbearing for mothers and babies alike. Sex education was not taught in most schools, and teen mothers were not allowed to remain in school and finish their education (Ooms, 1981). Proposals to increase efforts to teach sex education, provide adolescents greater access to contraceptives, and help teen mothers find housing and stay in school were initially met with substantial resistance; indeed, some thought this undermined parental authority. In the early 1970s, the Alan Guttmacher Institute, in its influential journal *Family Planning Perspectives*, first championed the need to provide teens with access to contraception and was soon followed by most of the major national medical associations.

The National Campaign to Prevent Teen Pregnancy—a nonprofit, nonpartisan organization—was founded in 1996 to provide comprehensive information and advocacy efforts designed to reduce rates of teen pregnancy across the nation. For more than two decades, it reached out creatively and successfully to national media, parents, teens, young adults, and community programs throughout the United States and worked together with the federal Office of Adolescent Health. Acutely aware of the sensitivities of the issue, the campaign was careful to involve national, state, and local public officials and program providers representing both liberal and conservative views—including abstinence education and natural family planning—on reproductive health issues. By focusing on prevention of unwanted teen pregnancy rather than teen births, it avoided having to take a stand on abortion.

Fast-forward to 2017, when the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention announced that teen births had fallen to the lowest rate since 1940 across all 50 states and for all racial groups. However, rates of unplanned pregnancy and births to adults are increasing, so the campaign now addresses young adult women with prevention messages and services, renaming their efforts Power to Decide. The principal focus is promoting easier access to long-acting reversible contraceptives (increasingly referred to as LARCs), which rigorous studies have shown are extremely successful in preventing pregnancy among teens and young adult women (Sawhill, 2014). Regrettably, no such methods are yet available for men.

Child Welfare Services

My third example of a contentious and sensitive family policy issue is child welfare prevention and treatment services—a broad area including child abuse and neglect prevention, foster care, kinship care, and adoption services. These are administered by the states but receive most of their funding from the U.S. Children's Bureau. In the 1970s, federal and state child welfare agencies were constantly under criticism as the numbers of children removed from their homes and placed in foster care soared

(Hubbell, 1981). Some claimed that child welfare staff removed children from their families too quickly, others that they were allowed to remain at risk in neglectful homes for too long. Occasional reports of child injuries and some deaths of children who remained in their homes continued to heat up the debates.

The Family Preservation and Support Program was finally enacted in 1993 and proved to be landmark legislation that has generally received broad support. It redirected federal Title IV funds from providing grants to states mostly to pay for foster care to also provide funds for a continuum of family preservation and support services, so that children at risk could safely remain with their families at home or, if needed, be placed in permanent homes as quickly as possible. The administration invested in funding substantial training, joint planning, and collaboration to make this systems-reform effort work (Cohen & Ooms, 1993). These reforms were updated and strengthened by the Family First Prevention and Services Act of 2018.

Domestic Violence

The domestic violence movement addresses the dark side of couple relationships. Its origins as a federal policy issue date back to the 1970s, when the first shelters and battered women's programs were established, and grassroots activists worked hard to get in place critical protections, educate police, and increase public awareness. Much progress in recent decades has been achieved by the effort of advocates who work with national and state domestic violence coalitions and the National Resource Canter on Domestic Violence. In 1981, Congress created the first federal funding stream for these core services throughout the country. The Violence Against Women Act, passed in 1994, was the first federal legislation to acknowledge domestic violence and sexual assault as crimes and provided federal resources to encourage community-coordinated approaches to combating what has become known as intimate partner violence (IPV). A growing body of research documenting the incidence of IPV in different populations and describing different types of violence between couples fueled the expansion of a wide range of services throughout the United States. Recent trends include greater collaboration between domestic violence and child abuse services (as they are found to co-occur), and building bridges to reach out to men as victims and as allies in prevention services, and working with relationship and marriage education programs (see Ooms et al., 2006).

Couples and Marriage

A final example of a successful, though initially highly controversial, family policy is couples and marriage. For years the public had bemoaned the "breakdown of the family," pointing to the problems associated with escalating divorce rates and unwed childbearing. Yet serious discussions about marriage and divorce trends and what, if anything, to do about them were largely avoided. Marriage had become the "*M*-word" in most policy circles for a variety of reasons (Ooms, 2002). One reason may be that it was not considered a federal issue. Marriage, like family, is not mentioned anywhere in the Constitution, and marriage and divorce have typically been viewed as the province of state government and faith-based organizations. It is state law that determines the conditions of entry into and exit out of marriage, and also establishes the legal obligations and rights of spouses toward each other. State and local court decisions interpret and help enforce these laws (Ooms, 2001).

The neglect of marriage policy at the national level changed in the mid-1990s as a result of the publications of several social scientists concerned about child well-being. Conferences were held and articles and books written summarizing a host of research about the negative effects of marriage and divorce on children and adults alike and stirring up interest and debate (Waite & Gallagher, 2000). Barbara Dafoe Whitehead's "Dan Quayle Was Right" article in the *Atlantic* magazine in April 1993 jump-started a heated controversy. *American Prospect* published a special issue, "Politics of Family" (Spring 2002), in which some argued that the emerging national marriage agenda was a regrettable attempt to turn back the clock and restore patriarchal forms of marriage. Others believed that marriage was evolving into a more flexible egalitarian relationship, which if it became more stable would greatly benefit children and adults alike.

In June 1997 in Washington, DC, the Family Impact Seminar held a national roundtable—*Strategies to Strengthen Marriage:*

What Do We Know? What Do We Need to Know?—for key research, program, and policy experts. The summary report, *Towards More Perfect Unions*, summarized the growing body of data, research, controversies, and proposed strategies that together made the case for putting marriage on the public agenda (Ooms, 1998). In 1996, two important and highly controversial pieces of federal legislation explicitly addressed marriage policy for the first time. The Defense of Marriage Act (DOMA) was speedily ushered through Congress and passed by large majorities. The act did only two things: It explicitly defined the words *marriage* and *spouse* in federal law as involving one man and one woman, and, in defiance of the Constitution's "full faith and credit" clause, it provided that no state would be required to honor same-sex marriage contracted in another state. It was welcomed by most conservatives and abhorred by many liberals.

The second, more extensive legislation enacted in 1996 was welfare reform legislation, the Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunities Act, which replaced the AFDC program with block grants to states. Three of the four purposes of the legislation referred directly or indirectly to marriage and family formation. The law exhorts states to promote "job preparation, work and marriage," "to prevent and reduce the incidence of out-of-wedlock pregnancies," and to "encourage the formation and maintenance of two-parent families." States initially focused their efforts on promoting work, serving more two-parent families, and preventing teen pregnancy.

In 2002, when this program was reauthorized, the bill included $300 million for demonstration grants each year to focus on promoting marriage and reducing out-of-wedlock births. (The federal funding for this program has since been reduced to $150 million annually, and some of the grants are awarded to responsible fatherhood programs.) The so-called marriage promotion grants came under a lot of criticism from the domestic violence community and many liberals for potentially endangering and disparaging the efforts of single mothers. However, opposition gradually died down after the assistant secretary Wade Horn, a key Bush administration marriage proponent, renamed the program the Healthy Marriage and Relationships Grants Program and required all grantees to consult with their local domestic violence advocates or services, which allayed some of the fears (see Hawkins, 2013, for a very reliable and detailed history and discussion of the marriage movement).

At the beginning of the marriage movement, any discussion of same-sex marriage was so sensitive that it was "off the table" and rarely mentioned, although the debates for and against were being discussed in academic journals and other forums (see Wald, 2001). The astonishing turnaround in public attitudes toward same-sex marriage since DOMA was ratified nearly 20 years after the act by the *Obergefell v. Hodges* Supreme Court decision of June 2015. This decision declared a fundamental right for same-sex couples to marry under the due process and equal protection clauses of the 14th Amendment of the Constitution. Some believe that this attitudinal sea change also may have increased the valuation of, and respect for, marriage policy and programs in the population as a whole (Rauch, 2004).

In an effort to reduce some of the inherent tensions in marriage policy, the conference Building Bridges Between Healthy Marriage, Responsible Fatherhood, and Domestic Violence Programs was held in 2005 at the Wingspread Conference Center and organized by the Family Impact Seminar under the auspices of the National Conference of State Legislatures and the Center for Law and Social Policy. The meeting brought together leaders in the three fields who had been at odds over the administration's Healthy Marriage Initiative. It was designed for them to get to know one another, frankly share concerns, present research, and develop some practical guidelines for how these practitioners could work together. The resulting report was found to be helpful and is widely used (Ooms et al., 2006).

As background, it is important to realize that the field of marriage and relationship education, with academic roots in the 1950s, had been growing in strength and numbers for several decades. The curricula and programs developed were intended to help individuals and couples make better partner and marriage choices, and to learn relationships skills to strengthen marriages over the long haul and thereby avoid divorce. The field was greatly invigorated and nourished for more than a decade through the Smart Marriages organization founded by Diane Sollee, her annual conference, and active online newsletter. It was then expanded by unprecedented levels of federal and some state funding

of community-based marriage and relationship education programs, which by one estimate reached well over 1 million at-risk individuals and couples (Hawkins, 2013).

A few religious leaders and many members of the faith-based sector are also involved in the healthy marriage movement. For example, Michael MacManus and Harriet MacManus, of Marriage Savers, advocated for community marriage policies in which churches would pledge in a covenant to perform a marriage ceremony only for those couples who had attended premarital preparation classes. Various community-based programs sprung up—some of them church related—designed to provide relationship education to individuals and couples. One of the most ambitious and successful of the community efforts was the Greater Grand Rapids Community Marriage Policy (Eastburg, 2001). In contrast to the growing number of states that were making it easier to divorce, Louisiana enacted a law in 1997 to establish the option of a covenant marriage, which (if chosen) would make it harder for a married couple to divorce (Sanchez, Nock, Wright, & Gager, 1991). A handful of states—Utah, Michigan, and most notably Oklahoma—started some modest marriage initiatives using TANF dollars. The Oklahoma Marriage Initiative is the largest and longest running in the world and predated the federal marriage initiative. I mention it in some detail because it illustrates how much can be learned from the innovativeness of state efforts.

In the mid-1990s Oklahoma had the second- to third-highest divorce rate in the United States, and a study by state university economists convinced Republican governor Frank Keating that this was not only bad for children but also bad for the state economy. In 1999, Keating launched the Oklahoma Marriage Initiative (OMI) and set a goal to reduce the divorce rate by one-third within 10 years. He used state TANF dollars to fund this multisector, public–private partnership managed by an independent, public relations firm, Public Strategies. The OMI team worked closely with stakeholders—including the faith community—and trained volunteers to offer free, voluntary relationship and marriage education classes to individuals and couples in communities in every county in the state and also to high school students, troubled youth, and even prison inmates. The educational curriculum chosen and adapted by the state was the most widely tested relationship education program, known as PREP and developed by researchers at the University of Denver, Scott Stanley and Howard Markman.

Oklahoma's 17-year statewide initiative was guided by a philosophy of continuous improvement and innovation, focused especially on meeting the needs and circumstances of low-income individuals and couples. Approximately 350,000 individuals in Oklahoma participated in free relationship-education workshops or classes sponsored by the Oklahoma Marriage Initiative, primarily funded by federal and state welfare dollars. From the beginning, a major commitment was also made to research and evaluation through establishing a national research advisory group and participating in two rigorous federal evaluations (Dion et al., 2008). In 2017, Public Strategies partnered with Child Trends and the National Center for Family and Marriage Research at Bowling Green in the new Marriage Strengthening Research and Dissemination Center, funded by a grant from the Department of Health and Human Services' Administration for Children and Families, Office of Policy Research and Evaluation

Over 10 years, the federal Office of Family Assistance awarded dozens of 5-year grants to community-based organizations around the United States to provide information and classes in marriage and relationship education to individuals and couples, primarily in low-income communities. The most recent round of competitive federal grants funded in the Office of Family Assistance, Administration of Children and Families—known as the Healthy Marriage and Responsible Fatherhood Program—emphasizes integrating employment and job training as an important component of services working to strengthen relationships, marriages, and fatherhood.

Although divorce rates have declined significantly—by 28.8% since their historic high in 1979 (Schweizer, 2017)—it is premature to attribute the decline to the growth of relationship and marriage education, as many causal factors are involved. A comprehensive and balanced review of the extensive body of evaluation of couples and marriage education programs states that, despite a few positive outcomes, proponents have been somewhat disappointed in the results. But it is also premature "to conclude that couples and relationship

education is moribund and research and funds should be allocated in other directions" (Cowan & Cowan, 2014, p. 370).

Hawkins (2016), in his extensive review of the evaluation research on relationships and marriage programs, concluded: "The evaluations are showing that relationship education works but just as important . . . [they] are beginning to show who it works for best and how it works" (n.p.). He then raised an important question:

> From a societal perspective, our relationship education services are not making a big enough dent in the problem . . . its underlying clinical roots—of direct service delivery—needs some rethinking to be able to reach out to all those who need it. (Hawkins, 2018, n.p.)

Hawkins proposed shifting to a public health model of intervention, which means developing and testing innovative, flexible, multilevel strategies such as micro-level interventions and media campaigns (as has been done so successfully in obesity, smoking, and teen pregnancy prevention). In short, "the field (of relationship and marriage education) needs to be a social change agent not just a service provider" (Hawkins, 2018, n.p.).

Future Directions in Family Policy

The family policy issues discussed here are not going away. Most of them will attract continued attention and support with only occasional setbacks. One troubling step backward, though, is the Trump administration's decision to separate children from their parents in immigrant families and imprison more than 2,000 children who crossed the U.S. border into Mexico. However, the uproar this action has evoked from all quarters reveals the depth and breadth of support for families and children across the country. Ironically, the pursuit of family unity had been the cornerstone of U.S. immigration policy ever since the Hart–Celler Act of 1965 finally replaced the immigration quota system with family unification. This principle had been warmly supported by Kennedy, Nixon, and Eisenhower, showing that "everyone from immigration advocates to bigots and nativists valued family unity" (Gordner, 1995, n.p.).

An encouraging step forward is the emergence of what are being called two-generation strategies—strategies that promote and simultaneously work toward the well-being of children and their parents (Meinert & Matthews, 2018). Programs using two-generation approaches have been in existence for decades (among the first was Head Start) and were reinvigorated nationally by the Aspen Institute's Ascend program, which is funded by private foundations and federal grants. This new initiative works to integrate this family-centered approach with the integration, coordination, and system-reform efforts of the 1980s (Hutchins, 1998; Ooms & Owen, 1991).

Initially, two-generation approaches focused on community-level services to adults and children, but they also have responded to state policymakers' desire to better coordinate service delivery to low-income families. The National Governors Association's Center for Best Practices partnered with the Center for Law and Social Policy to design Parents and Children Thriving Together: Two-Generation State Policy Network, an intensive 2-year effort. Both organizations provide technical assistance, peer mentoring, and financial support to participating state teams and governors in Colorado, Georgia, Minnesota, New Jersey, and Oregon to achieve statewide systems change through the development and implementation of two-generation strategies (Meinert & Mathews, 2018). In addition to this new approach, I turn next to emerging family related issues and what it will take for the academy to address them.

Emerging Family-Related Issues

An emerging issue is the growing number of prison-reentry programs that would be more effective in preventing recidivism if they could find ways to support the ongoing connections between prisoners and their families both during their incarceration and upon reentry into the community. Another issue is parents' increasing concern and frustration with the advent of so much technology in family life and the warnings from researchers of the short- and long-term effects of "screen addiction." This is leading to numerous calls for more tools and information for parents, and for schools to promote media and technology literacy.

We can expect a continuing focus on how to address child and family poverty primarily through increasing the minimum wage and more effective jobs programs. An interesting new emerging theme in these debates is a growing interest in social and income inequality. Data

are demonstrating the widening gap between the wealth and incomes of those at the top and those at the bottom. Richard Reeves (2017), of the Brookings Institution, has said that it is a mistake to point a finger solely at the spoils accruing to the top 2%. Instead, we need to acknowledge the large and growing tax subsidies and benefits that are enjoyed by the privileged upper middle class (such as himself) and their children and grandchildren—for example, the tax exemptions and deductions given for home mortgage interest, the 529 college-savings plans, and the plethora of unpaid student internships that are essentially unavailable to lower-income families. Reeves pointed out that attempts to reduce these subsidies in the name of reducing family inequality and encouraging greater social mobility have thus far been resisted (see also Sawhill, 2018, for a detailed discussion of strategies to reduce these inequalities).

I believe family and spousal caregiving of the frail, handicapped, and elderly is poised to become the most important, complicated, and most visible issue that will and should dominate family policy for a long time to come. Long-term care has been dubbed the "sleeping giant" of family and health policy because the systems and financing challenges of providing care to the growing population of the frail elderly, are already escalating exponentially. As more people live longer, they are increasingly suffering from complex chronic diseases, are at great risk of falling and injuring themselves, and various forms of dementia. As much as 80% of their caregiving is provided mostly in the home by family members—elderly spouses, adult children, and other relatives—at no cost to the government. Family caregivers must interact with a wide variety of health-care providers as they manage medications, dress wounds, give injections, provide transportation to medical appointments, and help with twice-daily bathing, dressing, and toileting tasks. Family caregivers play a critical role in the transition from inpatient to home care and preventing avoidable readmissions (Levine, Halper et al., 2010). In the process, family caregivers are often highly stressed and at risk of impairing their own health. Yet these caregivers are typically marginalized in the delivery of health care and long-term social services. Health-care professionals need training in how to communicate with and train family and spousal caregivers, who, in turn, need access to respite care and other forms of support.

A National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (2016) report provided a summary of the research and recommendations on family caregiving. Hopefully, these ideas will be translated into federal and state law and reforms in health-care financing to find safe ways to reduce costs of long-term care, such as providing more support and training for home-based care and family caregivers.

Bridging Academic Barriers and Taking Down Silos

Families remain everyone's concern but nobody's responsibility. We are learning more, but our knowledge remains fragmented, scattered widely across and stored in different academic and practitioner disciplines; national, state, and local agencies; and organizations—and also published in dozens of different journals, books, and reports. Hence, the knowledge and expertise is not well used. Numerous barriers remain to be overcome. Universities are the source of so much of our knowledge related to family policy, but the rigid boundaries between academic disciplines and the lack of incentives to cross them can make the needed collaboration and communications very challenging. To illustrate the crosscutting nature of family issues, I note that most humanistic academic disciplines have formed a family subspecialty to try to create these bridges (e.g., family economics, family education, family history, family law, family medicine, family nursing, family psychiatry, family psychology). It would be helpful if more political scientists were interested in family issues and if more family scholars and practitioners learned about political science and policymaking (Bogenschneider & Corbett, 2010). Ethicists have been involved in research and debate about family-related medical issues—in reproductive health, end of life, and other topics that deeply affect and involve families. But it would be helpful if more moral philosophers would help unravel the ethical issues involved in a wider range of social policy and program decisions involving conflicts between different family member's rights and responsibilities.

From the experience of the Family Impact Seminars and from recent in-depth interviews with state legislators, it is clear that policymakers highly value family-related research as long

as it is rigorous and nonpartisan (see Bogenschneider, 2018; Bogenschneider, Corbett, & Parrott, 2019). Yet so much of our evaluation research collects data on specific individual educational, health, or social outcomes but not on family outcomes. Further, these results are not often translated into the dollar figures that public officials and taxpayers most need. To make a compelling case especially to public officials for the importance of family policy, we need more "hard-nosed" economic studies, which can document the economic costs to society of not fixing certain family problems as well as the benefits of ameliorating them. Examples of these kinds of studies are research on the costs and consequences of teen childbearing by Moore and Wertheimer (1984) and by Kearney and Levine (2017). An earlier study by Sawhill and Thomas (2002) documented in numerical terms the strong effects of nonmarital parenthood on poverty levels.

Where Do We Go From Here? Making Family Policy More Visible and Important

Given the current highly polarized and politicized policy environment, it is unlikely that there will be major new family initiatives at the national level in the near future, and there may indeed be some setbacks. We need to think about new ways to make the family lens a more visible, compelling, and regular part of policymaking at all levels of government, but especially at the state level. Justice Louis Brandeis in 1932 pointed out that states are "laboratories of democracy" able to innovate and experiment without harming other states, and they may be able to lead the way. In recent years we have seen numerous creative efforts in individual states and communities to respond to environmental and social crises. This led me to ask which governance reforms could be instituted at the state level.

A recommendation that the Family Impact Seminar made to the 1980 White House Conference on Families was to change the policymaking process and institute a family impact lens, not from the top down but from the bottom up: "We propose that independent Commissions for Families be created by interested localities and states and at the national level to ensure that government policies help families rather than hurt them" (Family Impact Seminar, 1980, p. 16). Decades later, it may be timely to revisit the merits and feasibility of this commonsense proposal to establish commissions for families focusing at the state level.

Most people probably think of a commission as a temporary, time-limited entity designed to highlight or investigate a particular issue or problem. In contrast, this proposal envisages setting up family policy commissions as a semipermanent organization that policymakers, the media, community organizations, university faculty, and the public would turn to for assistance on family matters. Hence, I would like to propose that we call them "Family Matters Commissions," which hopefully is more inclusive and reassuring with respect to fears of government intrusion into family life. Family Matters Commissions would serve at least two main purposes. First, they would be a nonpartisan resource center to facilitate access to the growing but highly fragmented body of data, research, and program information needed to help plan and implement thoughtful, evidence-based child and family policies and programs. Second, the commissions would help inform and encourage, and sometimes convene, nonpartisan discussions about emerging family needs and concerns, to reach common ground on shared values and lead to some useful solutions.

These nonpartisan, independent commissions would set their own agendas. For example, they could help organize and sponsor meetings, conference, and seminars as needed, commission studies, and serve as a general resource on the potential family impact of proposed legislation. The commissions could be designed in many different ways. For example, they could involve community leaders and representatives of families themselves as board members and, depending on the success of fundraising, employ staff trained in the family impact analysis framework. Importantly, they would have access to and work collaboratively with many of the data and research sources and experts discussed in this article at the national level and, most notably, the affiliates of the Family Impact Institute operating in 20 states. The biggest challenge would be to prevent the commissions from being politicized, as the federal Congressional Budget Office has been able to do. Family Matters Commissions need first to be tested in several states, and if they are found to be useful, the idea might spread to other states and sources of permanent funding identified.

In summary, family policy is clearly no longer in its infancy, but it still has a long way to grow to become a fully fledged member of the policymaking and policy research establishments. Looking back on these five decades, I remain personally very encouraged and optimistic. We have learned so much, there is increasing agreement on goals and values, and a good deal of public and public officials interest in and support for addressing family policy exists. In this period of rapid change and turmoil, we need to keep on trying to find effective policy avenues to help all families manage to do their job well, so that they and their children and grandchildren thrive in the future.

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